

OXFORD

INTERNATIONAL
AQA EXAMINATIONS

INTERNATIONAL A-LEVEL PSYCHOLOGY

(9685) Paper 3

Report on the examination

June 2023

REPORT ON EXAMINATION: INTERNATIONAL A-LEVEL PSYCHOLOGY 9685 PS03 JUNE 2023

General Feedback

Performance on this exam was comparable to previous series, however this was the first formal sitting of PS03 outside of the disruption of COVID.

There was a distinct difference in student's abilities between the three sections on the paper. Students often performed reasonably well on Section A and Section B, with Section B often scoring the highest marks. However, there was a lower level of attainment shown for the research methods section. Within Section C there was often a noticeable lack of student's research methods knowledge and understanding, even on questions that tested the research methods content from their AS studies. It is certainly an area of the specification content that requires more practice and familiarity.

Overall, students tended to perform much better on AO1 skills, providing clear and detailed descriptions of elements relevant to the question. However, AO2 and AO3 skills were often of a lower level of quality for many students. On the other hand, there were some students who were able to produce outstanding responses across all three AO skills.

QUESTION 01

This question was answered well by most students. However, one issue that held some back was the lack of interpretation and engagement with the command word 'outline'. Some students simply named a characteristic of narcolepsy, such as cataplexy, but did not provide any additional detail. This could not gain any credit. Some moved beyond simply naming the characteristic but only provided a very brief outline that lacked some information. This often resulted in just achieving 1 mark. Those students who gained the full 2 marks were able to identify a relevant characteristic of narcolepsy and provided a clear but concise outline of how the behaviour of someone with that characteristic would be affected.

QUESTION 02

Students often struggled with this question. Despite many demonstrating a relevant understanding of what the question wanted, they proceeded to provide lengthy descriptions of research studies into narcolepsy. However, these rarely progressed to clarification of how and why these were either a strength or limitation of research into narcolepsy. Other issues often involved students identifying a relevant evaluation issue, eg the fact that much of the research has been conducted on dogs. However, these students did not develop their response to explain why this is an issue of the research and therefore of its conclusions.

QUESTION 03

Many students were able to do relatively well on this question, with some outstanding responses being produced. The main issue for some was the lack of engagement to the scenario. This was an application question and, consequently, any response given by students needed to have clear links to the conversation about the various animal sleeping habits between Olga and Anya. Some students wrote lengthy but generic summaries of some of the different evolutionary explanations of the functions of sleep without making any explicit links to the conversation. These responses scored very few marks. Another common issue was that some students simply rewrote large portions of the scenario that they had already been provided with. It is important for students to remember that, when they have a scenario question, they must of course use the content given, but try to refrain from simply copying the same information from the scenario into their answer verbatim.

QUESTION 04

This question produced rather variable responses. Some students were able to write outstanding responses which gave clear, accurate and detailed information about endogenous pacemakers and exogenous zeitgebers. These students were then able to effectively use relevant discussion points within their response, consequently gaining level 4 quality responses. Other students however only provided a brief definition of endogenous pacemakers and exogenous zeitgebers, before giving unnecessarily lengthy descriptions of research studies such as Siffre's cave study. These students would then focus on the strengths and/or limitations of these studies. Unfortunately, responses of this type tended to not move beyond the level 2 band as they did not focus on the requirements of the question; which was to discuss the effects of endogenous pacemakers and exogenous zeitgebers on the sleep/wake cycle. Students must read the question carefully and ensure that they tailor their responses to the requirements of the question and keep making links back to what the question has asked. Otherwise, they find themselves going off-track easily and writing lots of content within their response that is not relevant to the question that has been asked.

QUESTION 05

It was clear that many students knew what co-morbidity is and were able to identify and summarise what it means. Few students however included the crucial element when it comes to the issues of reliability and validity which is that elements such as co-morbidity, symptom overlap, etc mean that diagnosing schizophrenia is much more difficult. This missing element held many responses back from gaining the full 2 marks on this question.

QUESTION 06

There were similar issues on this question to those encountered on question 03, as some students simply copied large portions of the scenario within their response. Many students showed a lack of understanding of this section of the specification and were unable to move beyond the information that had already been provided to them. For example, many focused on the fact that Aisha talked to her friends whilst Zachary did not. Whilst this could have been applied by pointing out how this might affect any possible diagnosis of the twins related to how females are more likely to seek social support which might mask some symptoms and not having social support might make symptoms more obvious students rarely did this.

QUESTION 07

Most students did well on this multiple-choice question and could correctly identify the symptom of avolition.

QUESTION 08

Many students performed well on this question, often producing responses of a level 2 quality. As with previous AO2 questions, a lack of engagement in the scenario held some students back from moving beyond level 1 as, although they produced decent descriptions of cognitive therapies, they did not highlight how these could be used by Rosa to treat Mateo. Other students simply outlined the principles of cognitive therapy but did not focus on the requirement of the question which was to explain how Rosa could use the therapy. Students must identify key elements within questions such as the term 'how' and, when they see this term, ensure that their response focuses on this element, otherwise they will be unable to move beyond the lowest mark band level.

QUESTION 09

Many students could produce responses that gained at least 2 marks for this question. However, a lack of clear and specific focus on how anti-psychotic drugs treat schizophrenia held some students back from achieving higher marks.

QUESTION 10

Responses to this question were often very good with most students scoring at least 2 marks and just under half of students gaining the full 3 marks. Students were able to correctly identify a relevant limitation of using anti-psychotic drugs and could progress to give further explanation to clarify this limitation. For example, many students focused on the issue of side effects and proceeded to identify some common side effects experienced by those taking anti-psychotic drugs. The best responses then took this information and were able to effectively elaborate on how and why this was an issue in the use of anti-psychotic drugs. For example, people are more likely to stop taking medication if they are experiencing unpleasant side effects and this would most likely cause symptoms to return.

QUESTION 11

This shorter extended-writing question produced some varied responses. Some students could provide a clear, detailed, and accurate description of the cognitive explanations of schizophrenia, with many focusing on describing several different explanations in some detail. Some students however clearly knew various cognitive explanations but simply proceeded to list them, without providing any actual detail within their writing which reduced their access to marks. Students tended to be less successful at evaluating the explanations. Some did not provide any evaluation at all. Alternatively, some students just identified several evaluations, such as how cognitive explanations can be considered reductionist, but did not provide any effective elaboration of their ideas. Several students wrote lengthy responses which focused on family factors such as abuse and family relationships explanations. These were not creditworthy as they are not cognitive explanations.

QUESTION 12

Students performed surprisingly poorly on this question considering it focused on content from their PS02 research methods module. Just over half were able to gain 1 mark for this question, with significantly fewer gaining both marks. Many were unable to provide an accurate advantage of using a repeated measures design, with some inaccurate responses such as 'it reduces demand characteristics.' Those who gained 1 mark tended to explain a relevant advantage of repeated measures designs, however this was written in a generic way. The question specifically required students to explain one advantage of using a repeated measures design for the study given in the scenario. Students must remember that they should produce answers to these questions, that focus on the detail in the study that has been described.

QUESTION 13

Many students struggled with this question. Whilst some did show some understanding of what is meant by an interval level of measurement, for many students, their response rarely moved beyond gaining just 1 mark. The best responses to this question were students who could demonstrate they knew what an interval level of measurement meant and could identify how and why they knew that this study specifically used an interval level of measurement, ie the use of the stopwatch on which the scale of measurement is fixed so that measurements are directly comparable.

QUESTION 14.1

Many students were able to gain at least 1 mark for this question with just under half gaining both marks. It was reassuring to see that most students could show some understanding of why a related t-test was an appropriate choice of statistical test for this study. Some did not read the question fully and despite clearly being told “apart from the interval level of measurement”, proceeded to outline how a related t-test requires an interval level of measurement. Several students took a very confusing approach to answering this question and instead of specifically outlining two appropriate reasons, they instead stated that what the study was not: ie not a correlational study and not an independent groups design. Responses of this nature could not gain marks.

QUESTION 14.2

Most students were able to gain at least 1 mark by stating that the results of the study were significant. Some students were able to gain an additional mark by explaining that the calculated value was greater than the critical value in the table. However, only a quarter were able to gain the full 3 marks for this question. The main issue was that students had not identified the correct df value. They had been told below the table that $df = N - 1$, however they proceeded to look at $df = 20$ since there were 20 participants in the study, instead of $df = 19$. Consequently, their reasoning was based on an incorrect critical value of 2.086 ($df = 20$), instead of the actual critical value for this study of 2.093 ($df = 19$). Students need to remember to use all the detail provided with the critical values tables in their answers.

QUESTION 15.1

It was pleasing to see that most students did have some understanding of what is meant by a Type I error and were able to gain at least 1 mark on this question. Just under half were able to provide a clear explanation and gain both marks available. Those students who only gained 1 mark tended to provide a very basic explanation which simply focused on incorrectly rejecting the null hypothesis when it should have been accepted. To move beyond 1 mark, it was expected that students would provide more detail, such as adding that a Type I error occurs when the significance level is set too leniently, ie $p > 0.05$.

QUESTION 15.2

Very few students were able to answer this question successfully. This was because they had simply not looked back at the critical values table and realised that the calculated value of 2.889 in the study, was greater than the critical value for all significance levels at $df = 19$. Those who gained just 1 mark did make this point but, as in question 14.1, incorrectly identified the df as 20 rather than 19.

QUESTION 16

Surprisingly, many students struggled with this question. Whilst many did correctly draw a bar chart to demonstrate the results, few managed to gain the full 5 marks as one or more elements of the graph was missing or inaccurate. Students were told in the question to label their display fully, including the title, yet many did not label their axis accurately or provide an appropriate title. The drawing of the graph by some students was also very questionable with some using inaccurate scales. Students need to follow the instructions given closely.

QUESTION 17

Most students were able to gain 1 mark on this question. However, only a small number were gained the full 2 marks available. While most students could identify a relevant advantage of using questionnaires, they failed to expand on their answer by elaborating fully how and/or why their chosen issue was an advantage compared with conducting an interview. For example, some students focused on questionnaires being more accessible and convenient for participants as they can do them at a time that best suits them. This is a relevant and accurate advantage. This response however is limited to just 1 mark as there is no attempt to explain why this issue is a specific advantage of a questionnaire compared with an interview.

QUESTION 18

Almost all students wrote a relevant closed question. However, some did not gain the mark as they did not include clear and appropriate options for their question. For example, some students wrote a question such as “Did you find the memory test difficult?”. This however could not gain a mark as the student did not include the closed options for the participant to choose from, eg [Yes/No]. Students must include options for their closed questions.

QUESTION 19

This was the first time that an extended response question has appeared within the research methods section. It was pleasing to see that most students did not seem to be alarmed by this. Some were able to produce outstanding responses, gaining Level 3 marks. Overall, students needed to provide a general outline of case studies and then evaluate the use of these as a research technique for the investigation of human behaviour. Unfortunately, some students misinterpreted the requirements of the question and provided very lengthy and detailed descriptions of specific case studies that they had been taught within their psychology studies such as Siffre, Clive Wearing, HM and Phineas Gage. Unfortunately, students who did this received very few marks as the responses tended to focus on the details of the case studies themselves, ie what behavioural issues the person exhibited, rather than explaining what a case study is and how they are conducted. These students then proceeded to evaluate those case studies specifically, rather than evaluating case studies in general. Whilst they did gain some credit, they rarely moved beyond producing a low level 2 response. Description and evaluation of the different research methods is expected and students need to be prepared to do this for all the different methods used in psychology and that are identified in the specification content.

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